

Oak Woodlands

PHOTO BY BRIAN ROMM, GA DNR



SAVANNAH SLIMY SALAMANDER (PLETHODON SAVANNAH) BY TODD PIERSON

IMPORTANCE TO FORESTRY OPERATIONS

Oak woodlands in Georgia have historically been a reliable source of high-quality hardwoods, especially from species like white oak, southern red oak, and post oak—valued for flooring, furniture, barrels, and railroad ties.

These forests often grew on dry ridges and uplands, which made them more accessible to early loggers. Their widespread distribution supported extensive selective logging throughout the 19th and 20th centuries.

Fire historically maintained the open canopy structure, encouraging regeneration of oak and other fire-adapted species. However, fire suppression and modern land use have led to denser canopies and reduced oak regeneration.

Today, oak woodlands remain important for both timber and wildlife, with foresters and loggers using BMPs and prescribed fire to restore their historical structure and productivity.

HABITAT DESCRIPTION

Oak woodlands are mostly found north of the Fall Line. These habitats are dry, open, rocky, or sandy woodlands often along rivers or bluffs and have well-drained soils but can exhibit watershed overflow. Historically these habitats are maintained by prescribed fire. Numerous aster, sunflower, goldenrod, legume, and grass species populate openings throughout this habitat.

SWAP Priority Habitat

Ecoregion(s)

Oak Forest and Woodlands

Blue Ridge

Oak Woodlands

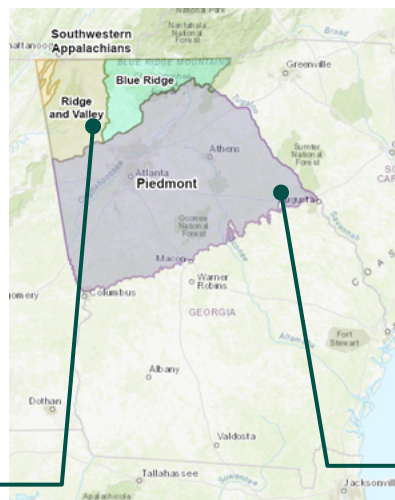
Southwestern Appalachians/
Ridge and Valley

Oak Woodlands and Savannas

Piedmont



OAK WOODLAND BY DAN AALMID



OAK WOODLAND SAVANNAS BY BRAD ALEXANDER, GA DNR

THREATS

- Habitat loss, degradation, and fragmentation, including clearing and conversion of habitat to agriculture, and residential and commercial development
- Fire suppression can degrade these habitats by allowing competition from undesirable competing vegetation.
- Overstocked stands can degrade habitat by creating closed canopy conditions and reducing sunlight on the ground.

CONSERVATION MANAGEMENT RECOMMENDATIONS

- Use selective spot herbicide and mechanical treatments to control exotic pest plants.
- Clean vehicles, tractors, and equipment between sites if invasive species are present. If operations cannot be avoided in areas where invasive species are present, conduct operations in these areas last.
- Reduce invasion by woody vegetation utilizing prescribed fire on a 2-3-year rotation or with selective spot applications of herbicide if prescribed fire management is not an option.
- If implementing prescribed burning, try to use existing boundary roads and natural features as fire breaks to minimize soil disturbance.
- Maintain open canopy through selective thinning, if needed.

MORE INFORMATION

Visit Georgia Biodiversity Portal for more information about specific species and habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIABIODIVERSITY.ORG](https://georgiabiodiversity.org)

Georgia's State Wildlife Action Plan has more information about specific management actions to protect these habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIAWILDLIFE.COM/WILDLIFEACTIONPLAN](https://georgiawildlife.com/wildlifeactionplan)

SELECTED PRIORITY SPECIES



See full list of Species via QR code below

Georgia's Forestry BMP manual is designed to help landowners prevent or minimize impacts to water systems, the manual is available online.

[HTTPS://GATREES.ORG](https://gatrees.org)

View the GA SIC Storyboard for more information and resources

